

Awaken the gamer in you

People make the mistake of thinking that being a “gamer” means you have a great PC or one of the popular consoles, and spend inordinate amounts of time staring at screens. Yes, those people are *video* gamers, but there’s a gamer inside all of us – you, me, our grandparents, parents, everyone!

The oldest known proof of a game is a Backgammon board and dice excavated in Iran, from the ancient city of *Shahr-e-Sookhteh* (the burnt city), which was built around 3200 BC and abandoned in about 2100 BC (basically 4,000-5000 years ago).

Almost everyone on Earth today, and certainly all of Digit’s readers have at some point played games and enjoyed them – cards, dice games, chess... something. Digit readers are just more into video gaming than the average Indian, but that’s just a difference of mediums, not natures.

There are several aspects to gaming that make it come naturally to humans. Entertainment is perhaps the most significant, since we all need something to do – perhaps why we watch the rubbish on TV these days, or listen to music, read, play games, etc.

Satiating our competitive streak is another big pull – it’s why we’ve always played games, sports and everything else in life – the desire to be *better than* the rest is ingrained in our psyche. We also need to exercise our minds, and that’s where mental games, or puzzle games, hook us. The brain releases feel-good chemicals when you finish such games, which in turn gives you a sense of accomplishment.

Anxiety or fear may sound like strange emotions that draw us to games, but they’re what add to the fun of everything – it’s why some of us love horror movies and nail-biting sports finales. Games also cause these emotions, and a rather tough battle in Chess will likely trigger very similar changes in emotion as when a hardened FPS gamer first played *DOOM*, or any other similar game.

Many people also love the escapism that games offer – visiting alien worlds, re-living events of the past or future, being a wizard in a kingdom of magic, or basically letting our imaginations run wild. It isn’t only video games that offer this either. *Monopoly*, for instance, lets us live out our fantasies of being rich property owners.

Video games, though, have some unique

offerings for the gamer in us – sex, violence and rebelliousness. The *Dark Side* in us all (males especially, if some studies are to be believed) needs to rebel against society and the morals imposed upon us. While most such gamers wouldn’t hurt a fly and are respectful of women, they will happily revel in all the blood and gore and sexist fun that games provide.

Rockstar Games has successfully exploited this Dark Side of gamers by hiding unlockable content of a sexual or violent nature in a game. Although it stirred up quite a ruckus and made headlines, and even got the game banned in some places, it only fuelled the desire of gamers to want to play said game. The forbidden fruit effect, so to speak.

Warning! Shameless plugs ahead: While SKOAR! – the next edition of which will be out with our December 2011 special issue – caters mainly to the hardcore gamer, Digit chose to look at how there’s a gamer in all of us for the specific reason of encouraging it.

I’m not going to sit about citing all the various studies that claim to provide evidence about whether or not games are good for us, because those are usually studying a minority of games and people – the SKOAR! type. For the rest of us, who probably spend more time playing *Angry Birds*, *FarmVille*, mobile games or *Solitaire* than any other game, what matters most is fulfilling our mental need of the hour – entertainment, competitiveness, escapism, etc.

This issue (and the DVDs that accompany it) aims to satisfy those urges by giving you some suggestions about which games to play. We try and show you how your love for a particular game can lead to socialising with like-minded people, and also take a light-hearted dig at a game that’s pretty popular with the Facebook generation. Of course, there’s always something for developers and SKOAR! fanatics, as usual, but in the end, our cover story aims to make the point that *everyone* is a gamer at heart. 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

“Almost everyone on Earth today, and certainly all of Digit’s readers have at some point played games and enjoyed them – cards, dice games, chess... something.”

Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com
and express yourself.